Request Yad Vashem award for: Geert Greydanus

Applicant: Jurjen Hoekstra, born 15-06-1941 in Leeuwarden, the Netherlands

in collaboration with:

- Ben Greydanus, son of Geert Greydanus
- Jenny Krabbe, granddaughter of Geert Greydanus and daughter of Wietske Walinga-Greydanus
- Jared Dijkstra, great-grandson of Geert Greydanus and son of Anita Dijkstra, sister of Jenny Krabbe.

Reason for the application:

On 15-12-2011 Jurjen Baron and Jeltje Postma received a medal from Yad Vashem for hiding of Leni de Beer (born: 30-04-1894 - died: 07-02-1990, Jewess, German teacher at the Erasmiaans Gymnasium in Rotterdam) from the Germans in their home in Suawoude.

This investigation originally focused on the question whether Geert Greydanus initiated, arranged and organized the hiding of Leni de Beer.

There are several arguments which make it likely that Geert G. did indeed arrange and organize the hiding of Leni de Beer in Suawoude:

1. Geert G. was a police officer in Rotterdam and consequently had access to police-files
2. Geert G. as a police-officer refused to "pick up Jews" (see the appendices)
3. Geert G. was family of Jurjen Baron and Jeltje Postma (see above under applicant)
4. During the war Geert G. was regularly in Suawoude and often stayed with Jurjen Baron, or with Lammert Baron, a brother of Jurjen Baron.
5. To go into hiding, Lenie de Boer travelled by train from Rotterdam to Tietjerk. There she was met by Wiebe Baron who transported her to her hiding-place in Suawoude (according to Tinie van Dijk-Baron, daughter of Wiebe Baron). Wiebe Baron was a nephew of Jurjen Baron and was active in the resistance.
6. Lenie de Beer was not known to Jurjen Baron or Jeltje Postma or any other member of the family before she went into hiding in their house.

But although this makes it likely that Geert G. did arrange and organize the hiding, it is fact that there is no definite proof that this was the case.

However, the investigation into the life of Geert G. brought enough other facts to light that we think that an application for an award is indeed warranted.

Refused to round-up jews as a police-officer
It is proved that Geert G. refused to arrest or round-up Jews, which was a dereliction of duty as a police officer. Conscientious objection was considered a criminal offense and he was fired with immediate effect. As his life was also in danger, he had to go into hiding. He went into hiding in Sinderen with a farmer called Satter.
There were more people in hiding in the farms in the neighborhood. And this place was also used by the "Resistance".
While in hiding, Geert was very active in support of the “Resistance”. In the appendix, Anne Schaap, son-in-law of farmer Satter, describes what Geert did. He gave shooting instructions to resistance-fighters. He also gave instructions on the organisation and execution of raids and robberies. His specialized training and experience as a police-officer made him singularly suited to give these instructions. In addition he transported people in hiding, including people of the Jewish faith, to various addresses. And he distributed the illegal newspaper Trouw.

Geert G. and farmer Satter spent a lot of time together and were both strongly motivated by their shared christian faith. Unfortunately they were betrayed and Geert G. and farmer Satter were both arrested. Geert G. was taken to Vught, where he was tortured and sentenced as a political prisoner. He was transported by former colleagues from the police to the concentration camp Buchenwald. It is clear that Geert G. paid a heavy price for his refusal to arrest Jewish people.

The experiences of Geert G. during his imprisonment are written down in a book.

Helping Leo Palache survive
A second story about Geert G. concerns Leo Palache.
After several months in Buchenwald, Geert was transferred to Niederorschel, a sub-camp of Buchenwald. This was a labor camp where plywood parts were manufactured for the Junckers aircraft-factory.
Leo Palache was the youngest son of Juda Lion Palache, a professor at the University of Amsterdam in Semitic languages. Juda Lion had three children of which Leo was the youngest.
Initially Juda Lion was a member of the Jewish Council. When almost all Jews from Amsterdam were arrested, the members of the Jewish Council were also forced to go to Germany, be it not in a cattle-train but in ordinary train-carriages. They were initially taken to Theresienstadt, a German “show” camp. From there they were transported in cattle-trucks to Auschwitz-Birkenau. Leo was send first, the rest of his family some time later. He has never seen his parents, brother and sister again, they were all killed.

Leo escaped this fait because he was moved to Niederorschel. The same camp where Geert G. was employed. According to the administration of the museum in Niederorschel Leo arrived on 30-31 October 1944. Geert arrived at the camp in September 1944.

When the Allies approached in 1945, the Germans decided to transport the prisoners from Niederorschel (527 persons) to Buchenwald. Due to delaying tactics of Otto Hermann's, the prisoners did not arrive until April 10. By then the prisoners in Buchenwald had already been moved to the south of Germany.
Otto Hermann was a German and was imprisoned for being a communist. He has meant a lot to other prisoners, and was awarded the Yad Vashem decoration posthumously.
The journey from Niederorschel to Buchenwald was brutal. Of the 527 prisoners, 102 died, of exhaustion or shot by the SS.
When Leo was at the point of collapse, he was helped by Geert G., together with another Dutchman. Had he not been helped, Leo Palache would for sure have died. Both Leo Palache and Geert G. survived and returned to the Netherlands.
Leo went to Rotterdam where he was active in the Jewish community. He passed away in 1996, aged 70 years.
Geert G. went back to Rotterdam, but the reception with the police was very negative as he had refused service. He decided to emigrate to Canada with his family and returned to the Netherlands only once. He visited Leo Palache during that time. What they discussed is not known.

Geert Greydanus died in 1962.

summarizing:
Geert Greydanus, as a police-officer, refused to arrest Jews. This was a criminal offense and often resulted in severe penalties. In the case of Geert G., one can conclude that this could have cost his life. See attached supporting documents.

Leo Palache was asked about the "death march" in an interview for the Spielberg Shoah Visual History Archive. When asked about his physical condition, Leo hesitated: I understand your question .... Apparently not that bad, otherwise I would have been lying by the side of the road. Yes ... injured feet, dried out, dragging ... but I completed the march.
Geert G. told his story repeatedly to his children and grandchildren and visited Leo P. in Rotterdam after the war and during his one visit to the Netherlands after emigrating. One can safely assume that Geert contributed to the survival of Leo P. And therefore we want to add this story as support for our request.

Renkum, 01-09-2020

Renkum, Nederland Jurjen Hoekstra

Clinton (ont.) Canada	Bernard Greydanus
Calgary Canada	Jenny Krabbe
Calgary Canada	Jared Dijkstra

Persons added also a copy of their Identify-card

Attachments: